FIR was filed in April after audits by the District Rural Development Agency (DRDA) confirmed inaccuracies. The scandal hit local media when two sons of minister Bachubhai Khabad (MoS, panchayat and agriculture) were among the 11 people arrested. Balwant and Kiran were later released on bail. The BJP said the arrests were a sign of its commitment to punish wrongdoers even if they were associated with a minister, but the political damage is likely to run deep.

The Congress legislative party leader, Amit Chavda, was at the forefront in exposing the scam and demanding action. But in Bharuch, Congress vice-president and district leader Hira Jotva and son Digvijay were arrested on accusations of inflating material costs through their agency.

The Nal Se Jal scheme saw Rs 123.44 crore purloined from funds allocated for drinking water infra like pipelines, wells and tubewells in 620 villages between January 1, 2019, and December 31, 2023. The playbook was the same: forged bills, bogus documents, inflated costs, bypassed tender protocols, contracts to unauthorised agencies. It was a unit manager of the Water and Sanitation Management Organisation in Mahisagar who filed an FIR in June. The 12 arrested include a government officer and some outsourced staff.



WELFARE IN ACTION NREGA workers at a forestry project site

TRAIL OF FORGERY

Gujarat's eastern belt has 27 tribal reserved seats. Tribals influence another 13 seats—a key factor, then, in 40 of 182 assembly seats. The BJP won nine of these in 2017 and 23 in 2022. The Congress's tally shrunk from 15 in 2017 to three in 2022. Dahod typifies this: its seven MLAs are all BJP.

Here, Chavda alleges, the scam covers at least two more talukas and accounts for over Rs 100 crore, but is being suppressed to save Khabad, a prominent OBC Koli leader and four-time MLA. The BJP's stoic silence has only fuelled those allegations. Its response would be critical if the Opposition—say, via Chavda's demand before the Governor for an SIT—manages to scale it up. ■

▶ JAMMU AND KASHMIR

FIRST-AID FOR THE STRICKEN

LG Manoj Sinha launches a mission to bring relief to thousands of families left broken by terrorism

By **Kaleem Geelani**

KOUSAR JAN USED TO SAY, as a little kid, that she would grow up to be a doctor. But then, while still in Class II, her life was plunged into a perverse negative of the paradise outside. Hapatnar, her village in Pahalgam, means the 'land of bears', yet it was the wolves that came for them. On a summer night in 2002, their home was burnt down and her father with an extra serving of brutality: his head and bullet-pierced body were found on two opposite banks of a water stream. "No one came forward to help. Not even relatives," Kousar tells INDIA TODAY. "We were shattered and homeless. I remember taking refuge under a broken tin shed."



Fear of the gun kept everyone away. Also, the social stigma that attaches to those that terrorists branded as 'police informers'.

Working at houses and as manual labour, her mother Zareefa Banoo did all she could to sustain her two daughters. But even Kousar, the younger of the two and the only literate one in the family, could study only till Class X. Ostracisation ordained that, after facing multiple rejections, she was married off to a visually